The Celebrated Pundit had many disciples and admirers. Among them was the landlord of the area who lived on the other side of the river.

The landlord had commissioned a poor milkmaid, Moti, to supply a tumblerful of milk to the Pundit, everyday in the morning. The milkmaid discharged her duty faithfully, day after day. She crossed the river by the help of a ferry boat and returned home in the same way after delivering the milk at the Pundit's household. Often the Pundit himself received the milk. Moti **prostrated** before him.

She did not fail in her duty even if on smoke days it retained heavily.

"What a great privilege it is to serve a great Pundit!" she would tell those who would sympathise with her for her continuous toil.

The Pundit was an **eloquent** speaker. Whenever he gave a **discourse**, hundreds of people gathered to listen to him. The milkmaid too made it a point to stand behind the audience. Not that she understood much, but she was sure that the Pundit was speaking about God and Truth and similar tough and complex matters. "How much knowledge the man must be possessing to hold so many people **spellbound** for hours. Only one who is very near to God and Truth can command such wisdom!" she thought. She was happy that she made a humble contribution towards the Pundit's physical well being by regularly supplying him with pure milk.

"Even if the landlord fails to pay me for the milk and my labour, I will not fail in my duty!" she **resolved**.

One day, while receiving the milk, the Pundit told Moti. "Woman! Can you bring the milk at the least an hour before the sunrise for only a month? I am under a vow for performing a certain **ritual** for which I need the milk that early."

"I will do as you say O Master!" the milkmaid assured him enthusiastically.

But the next day, by the time she reached the Pundit's house, it was already daybreak.

"Pardon me, Master", for my lapse. But what could I do?" said the milkmaid **apologetically**. "I was present on the bank of the river long before sunrise. But the boatman did not turn up that early even though I had informed him of the need for me to across the river while it was still dark! He said since the rivers is in **spate** it would not be possible for him to ply the boat in darkness."

"You could not cross the river without the boatman, eh? I wonder how then the mystics say that one could cross even the ocean of life by uttering the name of Vishnu!"

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